

The Breath in Ordinary Hours

This one runs all week. Keep it near where you sit. It takes two minutes a day, and one longer stretch whenever something lands. You're not writing essays here. You're taking notes on what the body does.

The sit is the training. Ordinary hours are where it counts. This journal keeps both in view: what state you sat down in, what breath you gave it, and what happened when you took the breath and the U-turn into a meeting, a kitchen, a hard email.

Take your time, and don't tidy it up. If a day is heavy and the practice slips, that's data. We use it.

YAY OR NAY

At the end of each day, one mark. Did you sit, or didn't you. No shame either way. It's just data. If the mind wandered the whole time, you still sat.

Day 1 _____ Day 2 _____ Day 3 _____ Day 4 _____

Day 5 _____ Day 6 _____ Day 7 _____

BEFORE THE SIT: WHAT STATE ARE YOU IN

Before you press start, take one second to check the quality of mind you're beginning with. Calm and clear? Jumpy and agitated? Dull and heavy? And the breath that goes with it: deep or shallow, rough or smooth, fast or slow. Then choose the breath that state actually needs. Five in, seven out if you're jumpy. A longer inhale, or a quicker pace, if you're dull. Even, if you're already even.

Three sits from this week. For each: the state you started in, the breath you chose, and what was different in the body when the recording ended.

First sit:

Another sit:

Another sit:

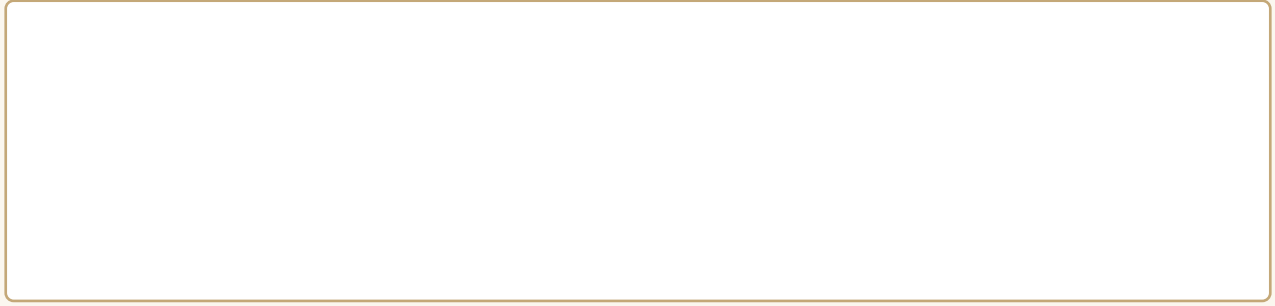
THREE BREATHS BEFORE

Somewhere this week, take three straw breaths on the way into something. A meeting. A conversation you've been putting off. An email you don't want to open. Note two moments when you did this.

First moment I took three breaths before:

What was different in the body walking in?

Another moment this week:



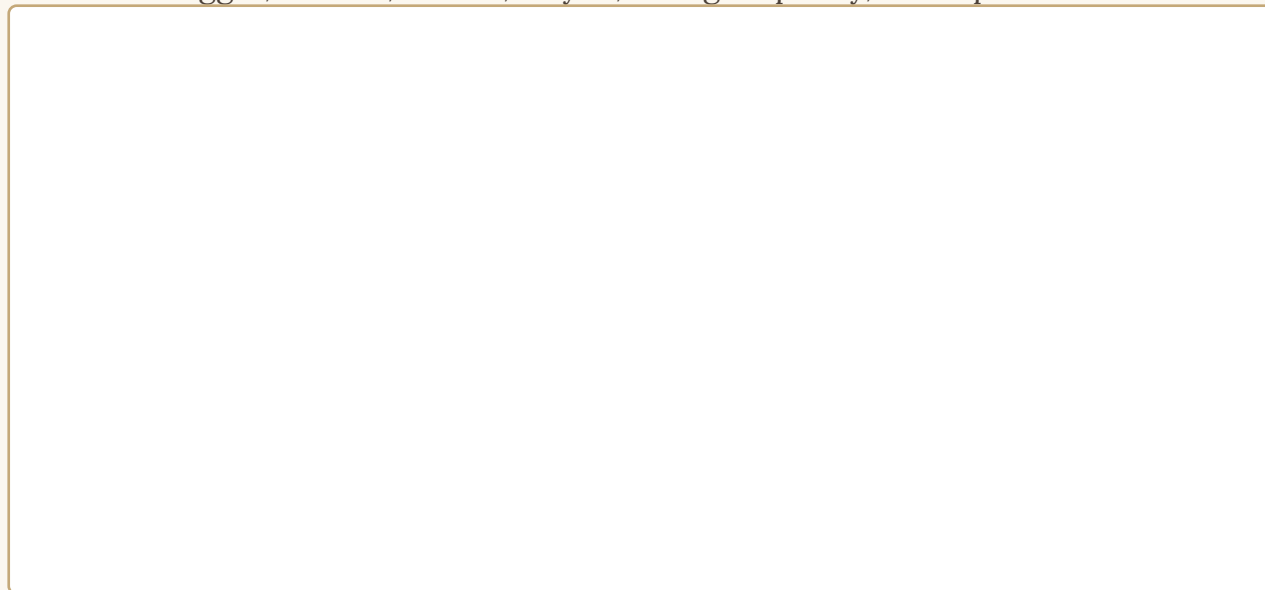
WHEN SOMETHING LANDED

Once this week, something will land wrong before you know why. Toes curl. Stomach knots. Chest tightens. That's the moment. Don't go to why. Go to what.

Where was it? Throat, chest, belly, somewhere else.

One word for it. Tight, heavy, hot, hollow, buzzing, numb. Then check the word against the body: does that capture the whole of it? If not, what word does?

Stay with it for a few breaths, breathing right into that spot. What did it do under your attention? Bigger, smaller, moved, stayed, changed quality, went quiet?



A PART OF ME

Take the sentence that was running in your head in that moment. *I'm anxious. I'm behind. I'm a failure. I'm going to lose this.* Write it as it was.

Now write it the other way. *A part of me is anxious.* Say both out loud.

What changed in the body between the first sentence and the second?